

WILD HAVEN
One of India's oldest protected forests, Kanha is home to more than 100 tigers

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MAOISTS FIND SANCTUARY IN KANHA

By Rahul Noronha

Some 2,162 sq km of lush central Indian jungle, home to the tiger, bison, sloth bear, packs of the ferocious Indian wild dog and...Mowgli? No, Kipling needs to be updated for 2022. The right answer is Maoists. One of the oldest protected forests in India, Kanha Tiger Reserve is seeing a bit of twist in the tail. Home to over 100 tigers today, it's one of the most popular wildlife reserves in India. But tourists keen on seeing the big cat in its natural habitat have a reasonable chance now of making another sighting. Maoist guerrillas from surrounding areas have been seeking sanctuary inside what was supposed to be a safe haven for endangered tigers.

The frequent spotting of Maoists deep in the 917 sq km core area of Kanha—spread across the Balaghat and Mandla districts of MP—has set alarm bells ringing in the security establishment as well as wildlife conservation circles. The state forest department flagged the issue with the police after patrolling staff refused to venture into many parts of the reserve following a series of killings by Maoists. The most recent was that of a forest chowkidar, Sukhdeo, who was apparently targeted after being branded a police informer. On March 23, his body was found just outside a tourist lodge in Mukki, Balaghat.

The murder prompted Union environment minister Bhupendra Yadav to write to MP chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on March 26, asking him to ramp up security in Kanha. A flurry of meetings ensued between the Chief Wildlife Warden and the state DGP, and a broad consensus was reached on moving security forces into the tiger reserve. The flip side, of course, is the effect this can have on tourism as well as conservation work. Even if Sajid Fareed Shapoo, IG, Anti-Naxal Operations, MP, calls it "a commensurate response keeping in mind the complexities of the situation".

Security concerns put a cloud on a big source of revenue for the state